

Public speaking

Almost everybody speaks in public from time to time. How long a person speaks for will depend on the occasion. It might be necessary to speak for just a minute or two, but a presentation to an audience or a speech on behalf of a cause might take a lot more thought and preparation.

▽ Being prepared

When giving a presentation or speech to an audience that contains classmates, family, or friends, there are some key aspects to consider beforehand.

Think about your audience—is it family, your peers, a prospective employer, or your religious congregation? How formally should you speak? What topics will interest them?

What do you want the audience to know? If they remember one thing of what you say, what do you want it to be? Be sure to emphasize this point.

Are you trying to persuade people of something? Perhaps you've had a new idea? Or are you presenting information about an important cause that you care about?

Think about the structure—is there a beginning, middle, and end? Do you want to include an anecdote or a joke at the beginning to engage the audience?

Be creative—could you use a poster or a video, or pass around handouts or photographs?

Will the audience ask you questions? Do you need to think about what kinds of questions they might ask?

GOOD TO KNOW

Public speaking tips

- Think about what you want to say in advance and write clear, easy-to-read notes that you can check if necessary.
- Be sure that the audience understands every word. Speak more slowly than you normally would, even if you feel silly, and pause after important points to allow them to sink in.
- Try to stand tall and maintain eye contact with those listening. In some instances, moving around and using gestures is a great way to engage people.

Conquering nerves

It's natural for someone to be apprehensive before a big moment, especially if they haven't had much experience with speaking in front of a group of people. Practice and preparation can help boost confidence on the day, as can positive thinking and a good night's sleep beforehand.



TEEN HINTS

Nerves and anticipation

- Try to be as prepared as possible—know your topic as well as you can.
- Practice what you want to say in front of a smaller group beforehand to get feedback and build your confidence.
- Be excited—it's an opportunity to share your ideas with an audience.
- Before starting, place your feet firmly on the floor, take a deep breath, count to three, and breathe out slowly.

◁ Practice makes perfect

To get a sense of the audience's perspective, it's useful to practice in front of a mirror.